

Why the Socialists are stuck on migration

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GERARDO FORTUNA CIAO T

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CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna back at the helm after a break. One source greeted my call by saying, "My rentrée was going well until you called. What should I worry about?" Relax: sometimes I'm just checking in.

In today's Playbook:

- The EU budget battle hits the road.
- A pair of Brussels power brokers is taking aim at Bucharest, with €770 million on the line.
- Faces in the crowd: Mario Draghi, Mette Frederiksen, Valérie Hayer, Christopher Nolan, Pedro Sánchez, Jan Szyszko, Giorgia Meloni, Friedrich Merz, Nicușor Dan, Wopke Hoekstra, Iratxe García Pérez, Manfred Weber, Elly Schlein, Léa Salamé, Vytenis Andriukaitis, Dominic Fritz, Luis Garicano, Jean-Luc Mélenchon and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian tee up António Costa's looming battle to get an EU budget deal.

DRIVING THE DAY

SOCIALIST STALEMATE: As Europe's Socialists head back to work, the feud over migration between Spain's Pedro Sánchez and Denmark's Mette Frederiksen is looming large over the center-left.

Will the Danes be ostracized for taking a migration position that's further right than many Socialists are comfortable with? Will the spat spill over into the European Parliament? Could it even threaten Iratxe García Pérez's grip on the Socialists and Democrats group?

Or will the Socialist family instead be gripped by political paralysis?

The Ceuta crisis exposed a wider split on migration that goes to the core of the Socialists' political values. On Aug. 1, a day after tens of thousands of migrants crossed into the Spanish exclave, Frederiksen joined other EU leaders in accusing Sánchez of undermining the security of the bloc's

borders. Last week, Spanish MEP Javi López and former Italian government minister Peppe Provenzano wrote to the Party of European Socialists (the Europe-wide umbrella group of center-left parties) attacking Frederiksen for aligning with right-wing Italian PM Giorgia Meloni rather than showing solidarity with a fellow Socialist government.

But nobody really wants the fight. According to nine S&D MEPs and officials who spoke to Playbook about the Ceuta crisis, the center-left is effectively frozen by competing national and European interests.

“We need to develop a strategy and stay united,” Vytenis Andriukaitis, an S&D MEP and member of the PES presidency, told Playbook. He argued that migration has become part of a “far-right paradigm” designed to deepen divisions within the socialist family and society more broadly.

“Our approaches on this topic in our Socialist family are a little bit different,” Andriukaitis acknowledged. Their priority, he said, should be to maintain a humane approach to migration without deepening divisions in their own ranks.

The row is likely to reach PES bigwigs before the October European Council, per another PES presidency member. In the European Parliament, the S&D’s leaders are expected to meet in the second or third week of September, two officials said.

Will they do anything? “This could well be one of those ‘we don’t talk about it’ issues,” one group official said.

“The debate in the PES has nothing to do with the group,” an MEP said, granted anonymity to discuss internal dynamics, as were others Playbook spoke to. Another MEP dismissed the letter from López and Provenzano as “the kind of thing people do in the heat of the moment.”

Two other thoughts popped up frequently in my chats:

1. Don’t mess with the Nordics: “No one wants a real fight with the Danes because then all the Scandinavians will go wild,” one socialist MEP told me. Frederiksen may annoy her Socialist Mediterranean cousins, but Nordic solidarity is still strong.
2. The Italians won’t storm the palace: One possible spillover scenario is that García — a close ally of Sánchez — faces a leadership challenge. But four group officials pointed out that Italy’s delegation is the only one with the numbers to take on García — and Democratic Party (PD) leader Elly Schlein has little incentive to grab the S&D wheel.

Schlein is trying to hold together an anti-Meloni opposition alliance at home with the 5Star Movement (affiliated with The Left) and Greens. Taking over the S&D could leave the PD clashing with its coalition partners every plenary. “We need to focus on elections,” as one Italian working with the Socialist group put it. “We don’t care about [group] leadership.”

The bottom line: Europe’s Socialists have plenty to fight about — but in Brussels, they have even more reasons not to.

BIG AND BREAKING

TAKK, DONALD: The Pro-EU camp in Iceland’s referendum has been boosted by Donald Trump’s Arctic saber-rattling, my colleague Carlo Martuscelli reports from Reykjavík ahead of Saturday’s vote .

CLIMATE BILL COMING DUE: After a summer of fires, drought and brutal heat, EU governments need to spend on climate-proofing now or they'll pay considerably more later, the Commission's climate chief Wopke Hoekstra tells Zia Weise in an exclusive interview .

THE 400-YEAR-OLD BIG TECH SHIELD: An obscure 17th-century Irish law is making it harder for Europeans to collectively seek damages from tech giants accused of breaking European rules.

KYIV SCRAMBLES FOR CASH: Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy appealed to European allies at yesterday's coalition of the willing meeting for help plugging a €23 billion hole in his country's defense budget.

DRAGHI ASSEMBLES HIS AVENGERS: Mario Draghi is setting up the Rhine Group with Stripe founder Patrick Collison to bring together policymakers, economists and tech heavyweights to push the former ECB chief's competitiveness agenda. It'll be run by economist Luis Garicano . But Poland's minister for EU funds Jan Szyszko blasted the lineup for including just one representative from the 13 countries that joined the EU after 2004 — former Estonian President Toomas Hendrik Ilves.

BUDGET BASH

LEADERS ON TOUR: European Council President António Costa and German Chancellor Friedrich Merz are embarking on a week of shuttle diplomacy as the EU seeks a deal on its next seven-year budget before the end of the year, Gregorio Sorigi and Zoya Sheftalovich write in.

Ships in the night: Costa kickstarts a tour of the EU's 27 capitals today in Bratislava, seeking to pave the way for a budget deal in December — before a crucial election year that will see France, Italy, Spain and Poland head to the polls. Merz will gather frugal Northern countries in Berlin on Thursday.

Slovakia first? Robert Fico is the EU's current problem child, so Costa's early visit could be read as an effort to sweeten him up. But a senior EU official on Monday insisted in response to a question from POLITICO that the schedule reflects the need to group countries geographically while working around leaders' availability. (Costa was in Kyiv on Monday for the coalition of the willing meeting.)

Berlin has taken an aggressive stance in the budget talks, demanding cuts of "several hundred billion" euros from the Commission proposal, which is worth almost €2 trillion. To build a common front, Merz has invited like-minded allies including the Netherlands, Finland, Austria and Denmark to his Thursday summit.

Pas vous, Manu: French President Emmanuel Macron wasn't invited — despite Merz vowing just over a month ago , after hosting him in Berlin, that Paris and Berlin would work together on this issue and others.

Costa-to-Costa: The Berlin summit coincides with Costa's tour of the capitals, which will take him to Slovakia, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania and Czechia this week. Costa intends to visit every EU country except Sweden, which holds an election in September, to better understand where each EU leader stands on the budget and other priorities such as migration and competitiveness.

Grand finale: Costa will head to Ireland toward the end of his tour, to brief PM Micheál Martin on his takeaways. The rotating Irish Council presidency must produce a new budget negotiating document before an October leaders' summit.

TAKING AIM AT ROMANIA

EXCLUSIVE — COMMISSION URGED TO WITHHOLD FUNDS: The center-right European People's Party and liberal Renew Europe groups are asking Commission President Ursula von der Leyen to withhold €770 million of EU money from Romania due to rule of law concerns, according to a letter seen by Max Grier.

Big guns: EPP chief Manfred Weber and Renew leader Valérie Hayer asked von der Leyen "to make it unequivocally clear" that the money — part of the EU's post-pandemic recovery cash pot — won't be released unless Bucharest drops plans to amend a law that could lead to the head of a liberal party being barred from office.

In a nutshell: The Social Democrats (PSD), with far-right party AUR's support, introduced an amendment to a law on integrity in office that could see USR party leader and Timișoara Mayor Dominic Fritz barred over a past conflict of interest case. Weber and Hayer say its retroactive application breaches EU law and Romania's constitution — and accuse PSD of deliberately targeting Fritz.

"European taxpayers' money must never become a blank check for political power plays," Hayer told Playbook. Weber added that "if legislation is tailored to remove a political opponent, and EU funds are used as leverage to push it through, this is no longer just politics — it is a rule-of-law concern."

Hoping for a sign: In the letter, they urge the Commission to send "a signal" before Romanian President Nicușor Dan signs off the law, and before the Aug. 31 deadline for reforms that would release the EU cash.

What this is really about: There's been a month-long deadlock since PSD torpedoed a national government coalition with the help of the far right. PSD did not reply to a request for comment.

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

THE NOLAN EFFECT: Greece is hoping for a tourism bonanza from Christopher Nolan's "Odyssey."

WATCH AND LEARN? The EU is keeping its head down after Donald Trump threatened tariffs of 50 percent on Canadian cars, auto parts and steel (with Canada set to hit back). More in Morning Trade for subscribers.

MANG-NIFIQUE: Saudi Arabia is dropping €6 billion on three theme parks outside Paris — including a manga-themed attraction that POLITICO revealed earlier this month.

THE NIGHTMARE SCENARIO MOVES CLOSER: The battle of extremes that Brussels fears in the 2027 French presidential election is looking a little less hypothetical , with a new poll suggesting Jean-Luc Mélenchon could squeeze past the centrist field to face Marine Le Pen in Round 2.

PUT DOWN THAT PHONE, KID: France is pressing ahead with a ban on phones in high schools, even after Emmanuel Macron's wider under-15 social media crackdown hit a constitutional wall ... One to watch as Commission President Ursula von der Leyen pursues her own plans to limit children's social media use.

NEVER BE THE STORY: French news anchor Léa Salamé is temporarily stepping away from hosting public TV's primetime bulletin while her partner Raphaël Glucksmann runs for president.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mostly sunny. High 25C.

BAD NEWS FOR TRAFFIC IN THE EU QUARTER: There's a new construction site on Rue Belliard, which has narrowed the road significantly. Sibelga is working to install cables, pipes and ducts, which is expected to last until Dec. 18 .

HOME AWAY FROM HOME: Brussels' Union Saint-Gilloise will play its four home matches in the league phase of the Europa League at the Den Dreef stadium in Leuven, the football club announced Monday. Union's own Joseph Marien stadium in Forest doesn't meet UEFA's requirements for European football. The draw for the Europa League is scheduled for Friday.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Ian asked whether you've ever been inspired to visit somewhere after seeing it in a film. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz is taking his restless Cabinet on a team-building retreat before a perilous September, with economic reform, industrial renewal and drones on the agenda.

Paris: Edouard Philippe and Gabriel Attal are trading blows as they vie for France's centrist presidential vote , but neither is making headway — and Jean-Luc Mélenchon is on the rise.

London: Andy Burnham will today unveil plans for a national house-building drive — but critics are already saying it falls short of what he promised during his leadership bid.

Washington: Some Republicans are trying to stop foreign money flowing through America's booming political influencer economy before it further taints the MAGA brand.

Canberra: Australia's role in AUKUS will again come under scrutiny at a citizen-led inquiry hearing ... while Anthony Albanese explains his AI vision in a speech to business leaders.

AGENDA

— European Council President António Costa visits Bratislava, where he meets Slovak Prime Minister Robert Fico before traveling to Tallinn for talks with Estonian Prime Minister Kristen Michal.

— Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen speaks at the annual meeting of heads of mission in Helsinki and participates in a panel with Elina Valtonen, Finland's foreign affairs minister.

— Equality Commissioner Hadja Lahbib visits the Hautes Fagnes in Belgium and Monschau in Germany.

— Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica participates in the Conference of Croatian Ambassadors in Zagreb.

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis visits Riga Technical University and participates in the opening of the Talent Programme's 2026-27 academic year.

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall participates in a high-level roundtable hosted by the Stockholm International Water Institute as part of World Water Week 2026; and visits Xylem's research and development facility in Stockholm.

— The Council's Working Party of Financial Counsellors meets at 10 a.m.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Krzysztof Śmiszek; former MEPs Francesca Donato and Barbara Ann Gibson; POLITICO's Christian Oliver; Axel Springer Premium-Gruppe International Political Anchor Gordon Repinski; Finnish Forest Industries Federation's Kaisa Karvala; ORF's Raffaella Schaidreiter and IMF's Martin Caudron.

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